USER MANUAL

Broker Desk

Your insurance policy tracker: clients, policies, payments, renewals, commissions, meetings and reports in one place.

The screenshots use made-up demo clients. Your own screens show your own data.

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1. Getting started

Signing in

Open your Broker Desk web address (for example `https://yourname.pythonanywhere.com`) and enter your password. You stay signed in on that device for two weeks. To sign out, click **Sign out** at the top right. Always sign out on a shared or public computer.

Bookmark the address on your phone too. Every page works on a phone.

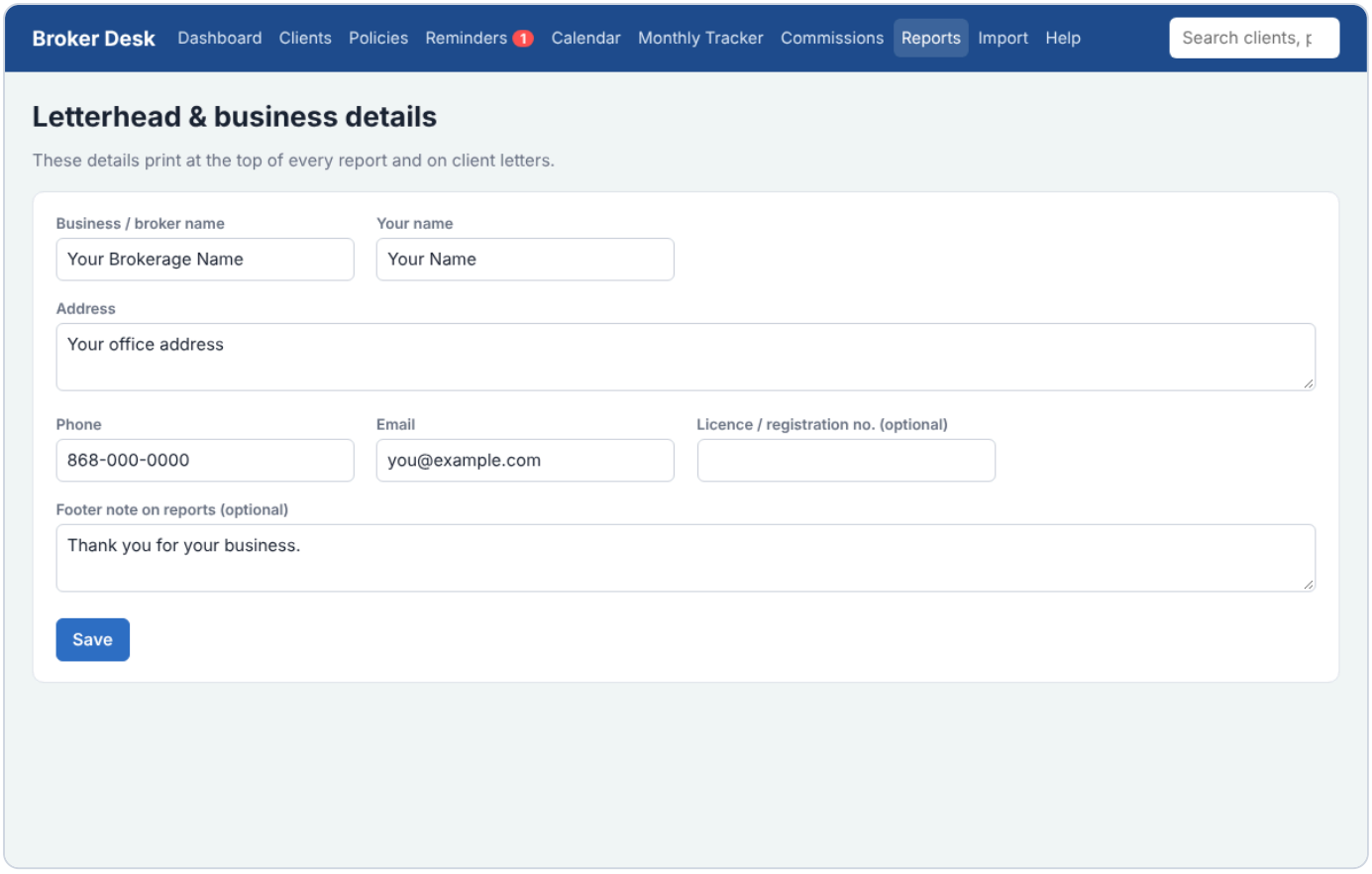
The menu

Menu item	What it's for
Dashboard	Today at a glance: payments overdue and due, this week's meetings, to-dos and renewals.
Clients	Everyone you insure: contact details and all their policies.
Policies	Every policy, with filters by type and status.
Reminders	Who needs to pay, who is renewing, and your own to-do list. The red number shows how many things are overdue.
Calendar	Your meetings, plus payment dates, renewals and to-dos, month by month.
Monthly Tracker	Month by month: who renews, who paid, and whether commission came in.
Commissions	Every commission line from the insurer's statements, with monthly totals.
Reports	Printable letters for clients and reports for insurance companies.
Import	Upload the insurer's Excel reports, and download a backup.
Help	This manual.

The **search box** at the top finds clients by name, phone or email, and policies by policy number, insurer or insured item (such as a vehicle registration).

First-time setup (5 minutes)

1. Go to Reports → Letterhead & business details and enter your business name, your name, address, phone and email. These print at the top of every report and letter.
2. Go to Import and upload your latest renewal listing and commission statements (see section 9). This fills in most of your clients and policies for you.
3. Add any clients and policies that aren't on those reports by hand (see section 4).

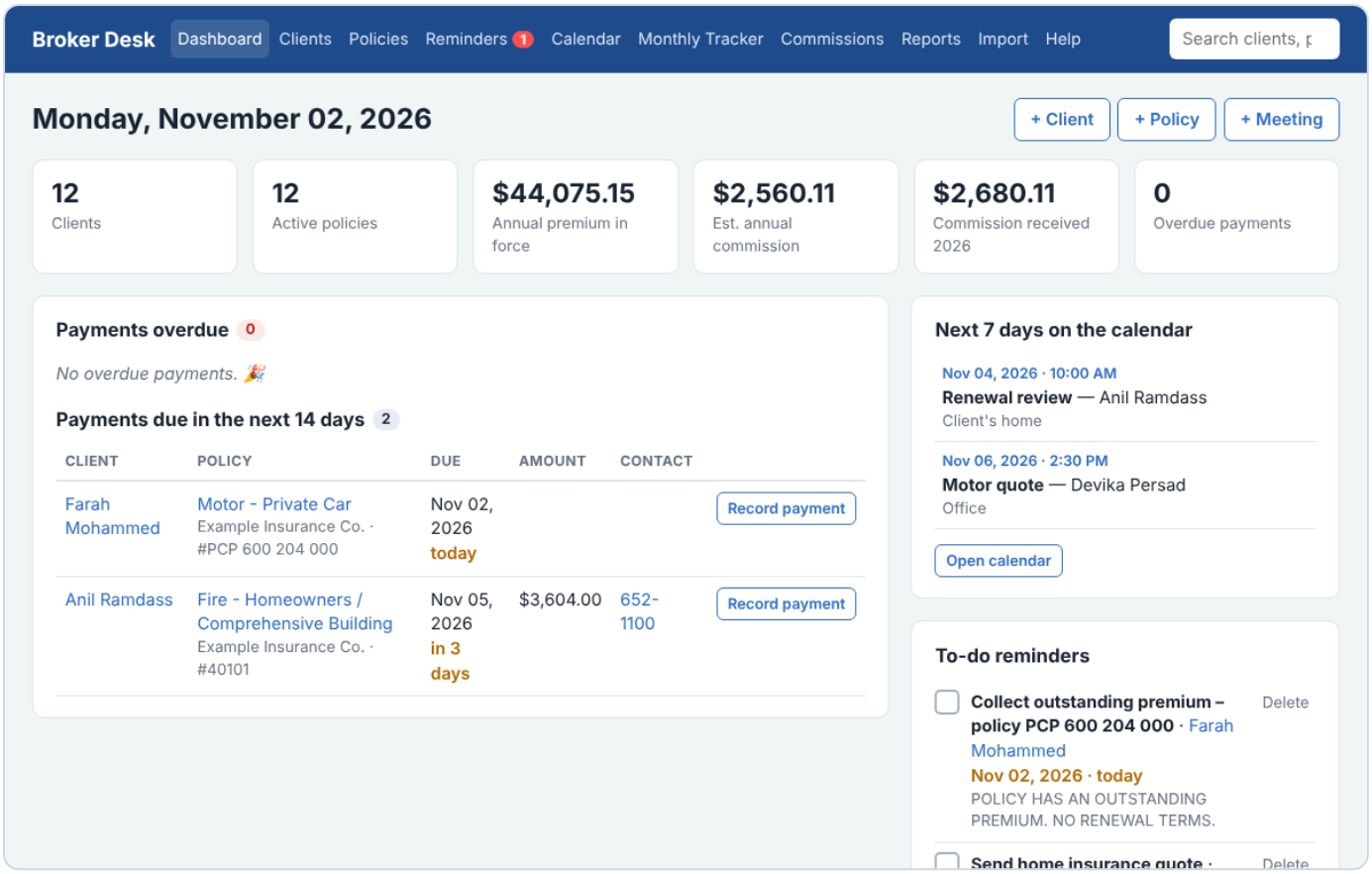


Letterhead & business details: fill this in once.

2. A suggested routine

When	What to do
Every day	Open the **Dashboard**. Call or email anyone under *Payments overdue*. Check today's meetings and to-dos. When a client pays, click **Record payment**.
Every week	Open **Reminders** and look at the next 30 days of payments and the renewals coming up. Send renewal notices and book review meetings.
Every month, when the insurer sends reports	**Import** the renewal listing and the commission statement. Then open the **Monthly Tracker** and filter by *Paid, commission not received* to see commissions to query. Print the *Commission reconciliation / query* report for the insurer if needed. Finish with **Download backup**.
Every 3 months	Click *Run until 3 months from today* on PythonAnywhere (online version only, see section 15).

3. The Dashboard



The Dashboard

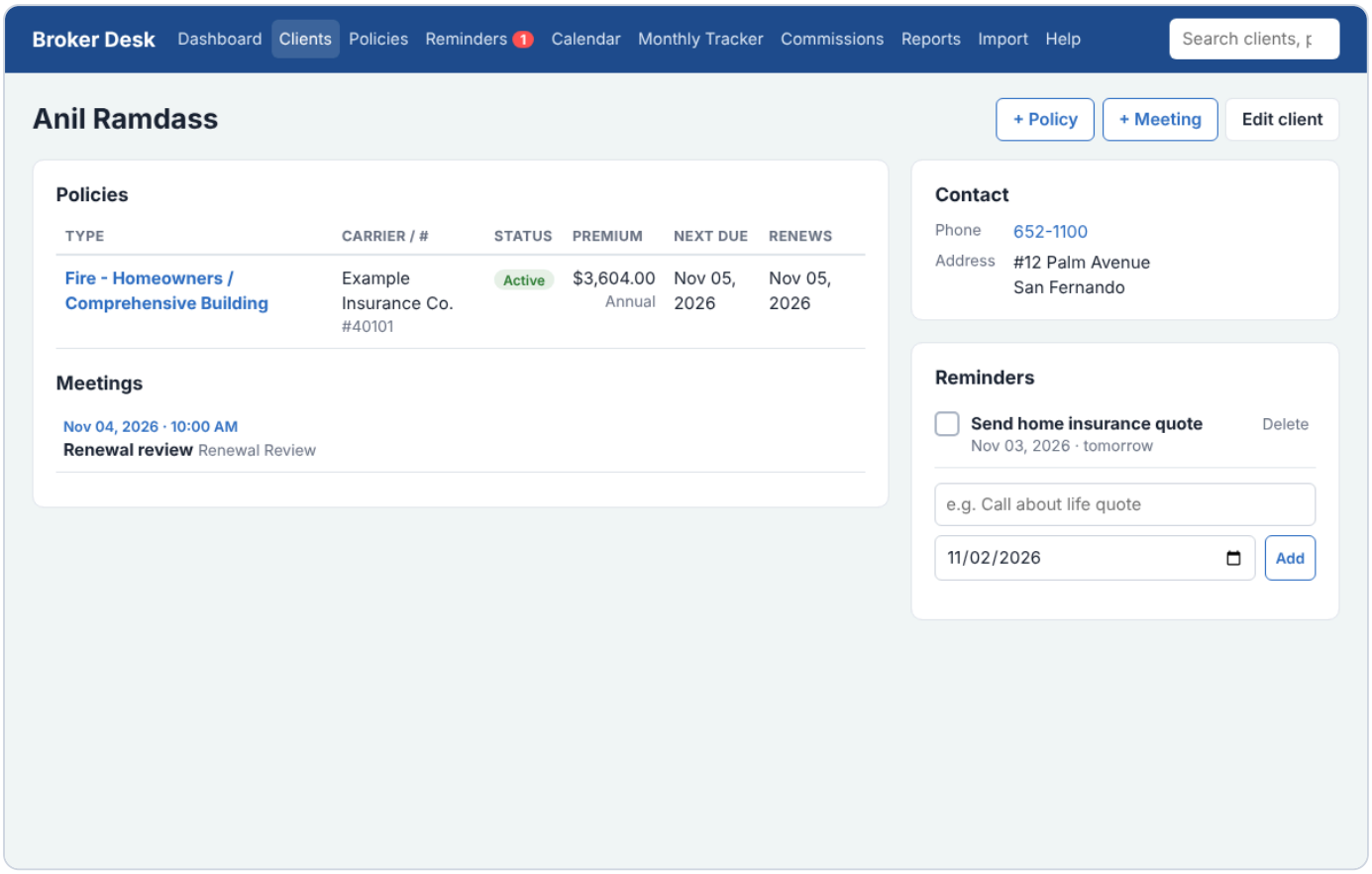
- **Top boxes:** number of clients and active policies, total annual premium in force, estimated annual commission, commission actually received this year, and payments overdue (red when there are any).
- **Payments overdue:** active policies whose payment date has passed. Each row shows the client's phone number, an **Email reminder** button that opens your email with a polite payment reminder already written, and **Record payment**.
- **Payments due in the next 14 days**: the same, for payments coming up.
- **Next 7 days on the calendar:** your meetings. Click one to open it.
- **To-do reminders:** tick the box when something is done.
- **Renewals in the next 60 days:** with **Email client** and **Schedule review** buttons.

4. Clients

Adding a client

1. Click **Clients → + New client** (or **+ Client** on the Dashboard).
2. Fill in the name and whatever contact details you have. Only the last name is required.
3. For a **business** (such as "Coral Bay Traders Limited"), leave *First name* blank and put the business name in *Last name / business name*.
4. Click **Save**.

The client page



A client page: policies, meetings, contact details and reminders together.

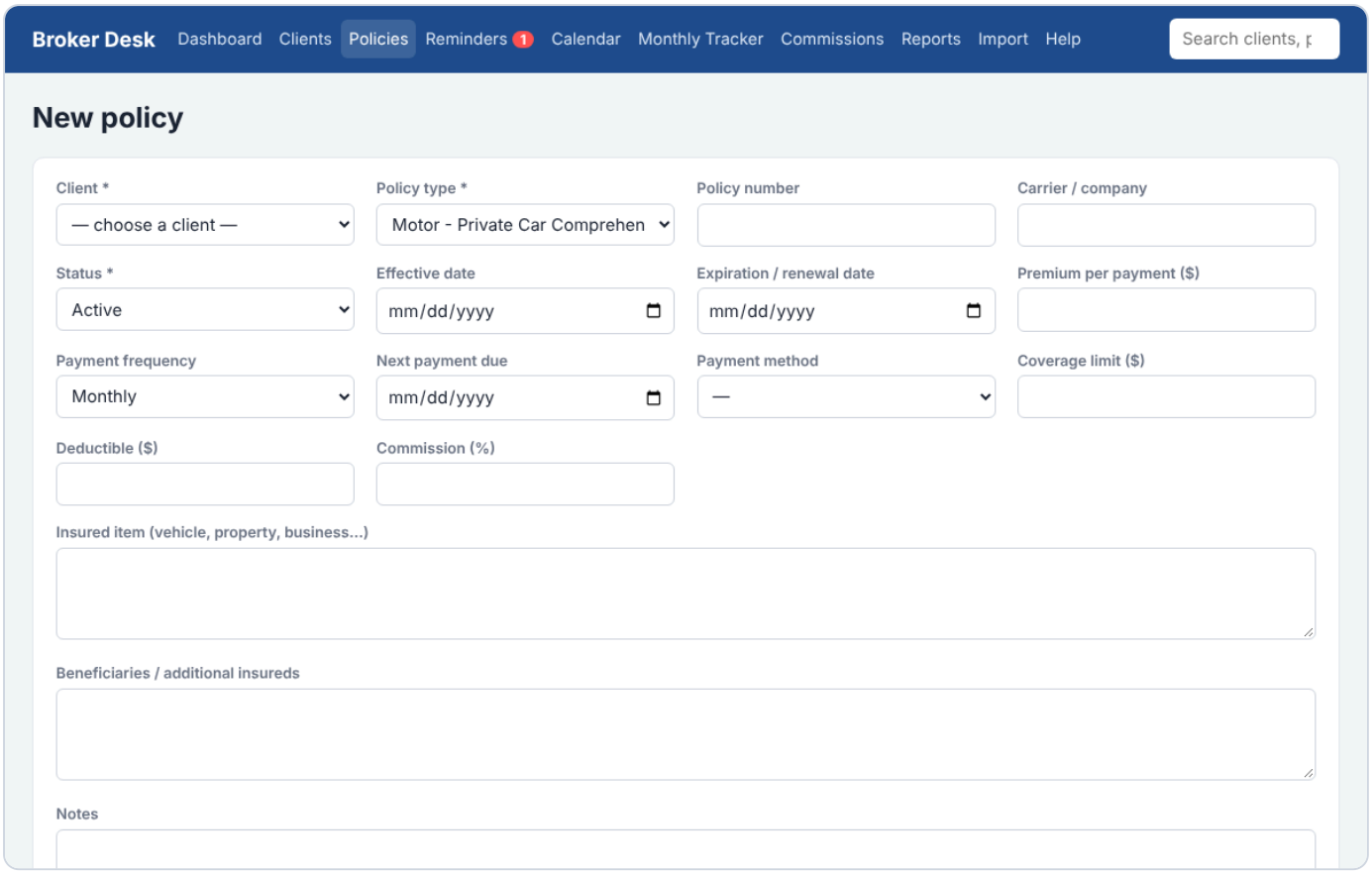
From a client's page you can add a policy or meeting for them, edit their details, and add a reminder that's linked to them. Click a phone number to call it from your phone, or an email address to write to them.

Deleting a client (Edit client → Delete) also deletes all their policies, payments and reminders. It can't be undone, so take a backup first if unsure.

5. Policies

Adding a policy

Open the client and click **+ Policy**, or use **Policies → + New policy**.



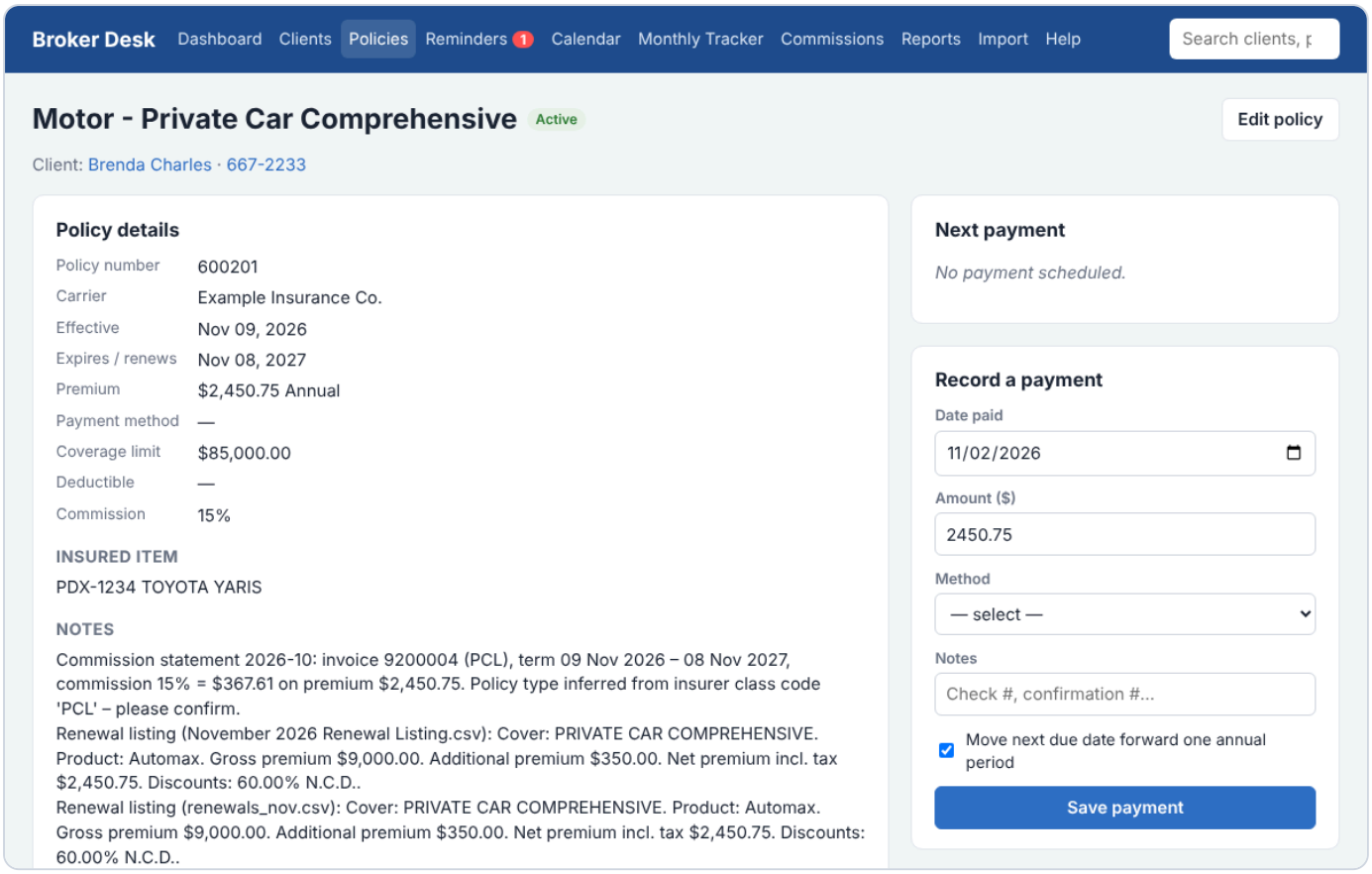
The policy form

Field	What to enter
Policy type	Motor (private car or commercial, comprehensive or third party), Fire (homeowners or commercial), Public Liability, Workers' Compensation, Life, Health and others.
Status	*Active* (in force), *Pending*, *Quoted*, *Lapsed*, *Cancelled* or *Expired*. Only Active policies produce payment reminders.
Effective / Expiration date	The period of insurance. The expiration date is used for renewal reminders.
Premium per payment	The amount the client pays each time, together with the *Payment frequency* (Monthly, Quarterly, Semi-Annual, Annual or Paid in Full).
Next payment due	The date of the next payment. This drives the overdue and due-soon lists.

Coverage limit, Deductible	The sum insured and the excess.
Commission (%)	Your commission rate. It's used for the estimated commission figures.
Insured item	Vehicle registration and model, property address, or business details.
Beneficiaries / additional insureds	Life beneficiaries, mortgagees or named drivers.

Policies brought in by an import already have most of these filled in, with the insurer's details (cover type, discounts, gross and net premium) saved in *Notes*.

6. Recording payments



A policy page: details on the left, Record a payment on the right.

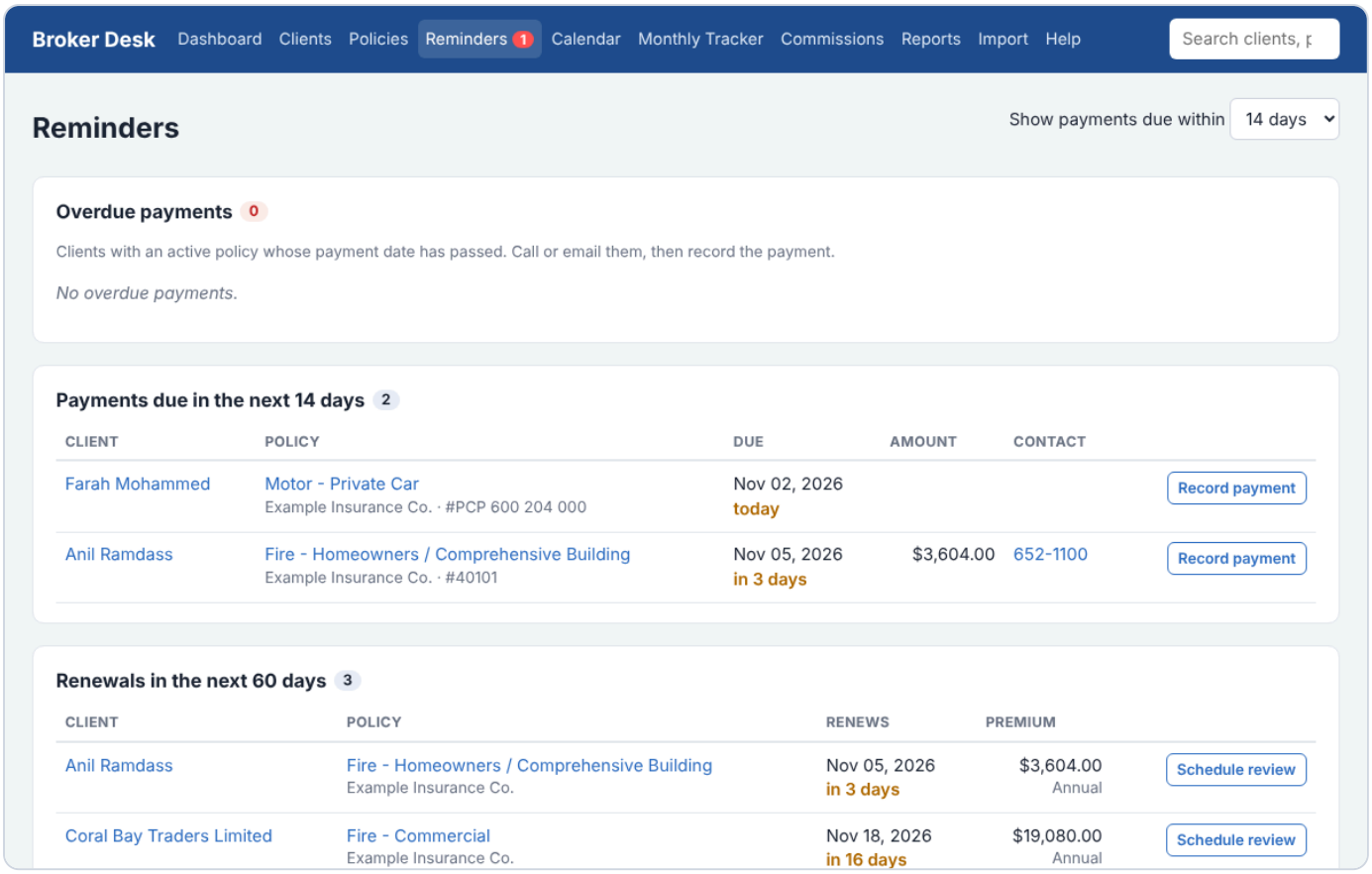
1. Open the policy (from the client page, the Policies list, or **Record payment** on the Dashboard).
2. Under **Record a payment**, check the date, amount and method. Add a cheque or receipt number in *Notes* if you like.
3. Leave **Move next due date forward** ticked. The next payment date then moves on by one month, quarter, half-year or year, according to the payment frequency.
4. Click **Save payment**.

If the payment is the **renewal premium**, the policy also moves into its new one-year term automatically, and it drops off the renewals list.

Every payment is listed under **Payment history**. If you made a mistake, click **Remove** next to the payment. The due date isn't changed back automatically, so correct it with **Edit policy** if needed.

The **Email payment reminder** button at the top of a policy opens your email program with a reminder to the client already written. Read it, change it if you like, and send.

7. Reminders



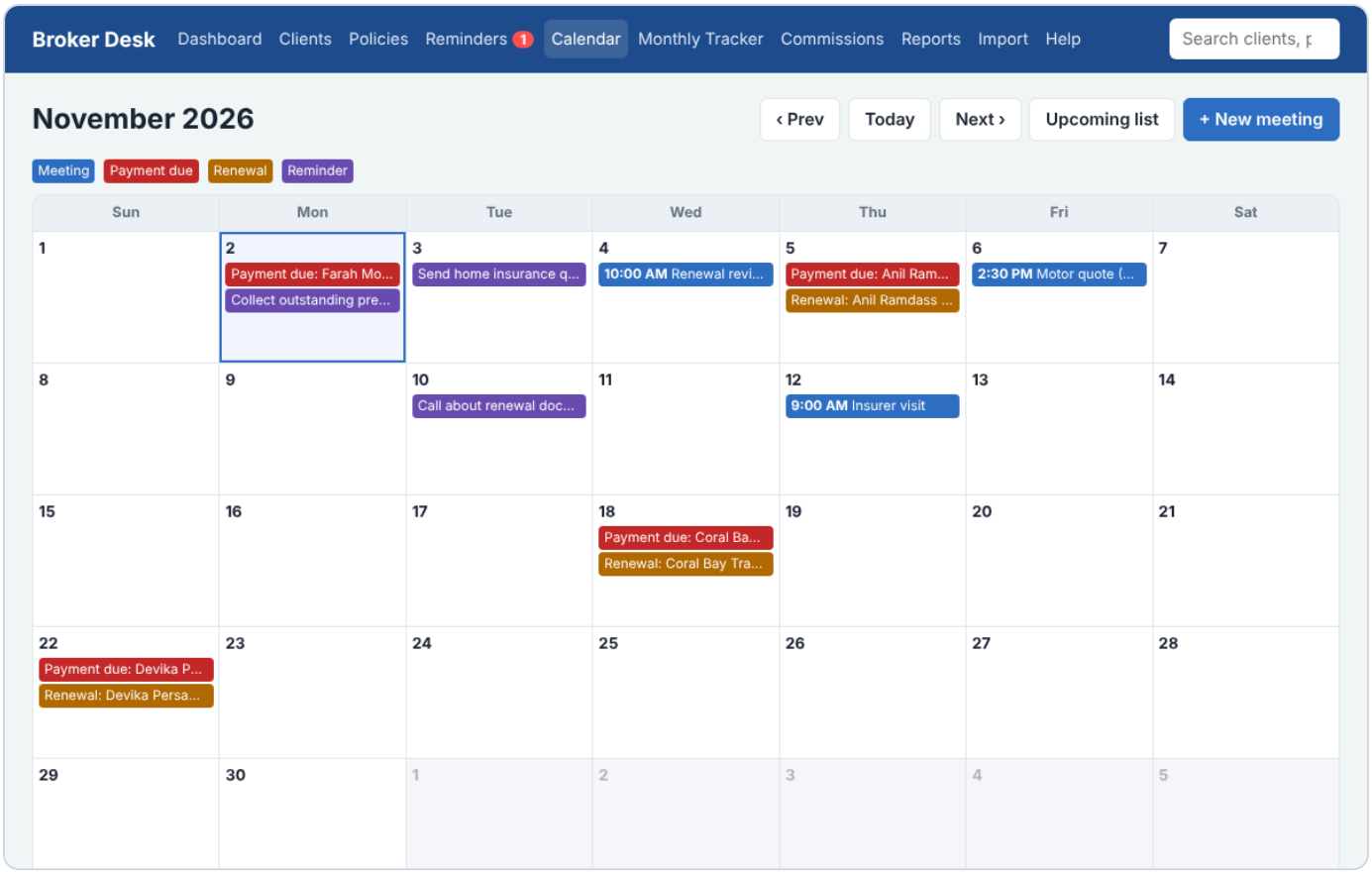
The Reminders page

- **Overdue payments:** clients who still owe. Highlighted in red.
- **Payments due in the next…** days: choose 7, 14, 30, 60 or 90 days at the top.
- **Renewals in the next 60 days.**
- **My to-do reminders:** type what you need to remember, pick a date and (optionally) a client, then click **Add reminder**. Tick the box when it's done.

When an imported renewal listing says a policy has an *outstanding premium*, a to-do reminder *"Collect outstanding premium – policy …"* is created for you automatically.

> Reminders show inside Broker Desk. They don't send you texts or emails, so make opening the Dashboard part of your morning.

8. Calendar and meetings



The Calendar: meetings (blue), payments due (red), renewals (orange) and to-dos (purple).

- Click a **day number** to add a meeting on that day, or click **+ New meeting**.
- Give it a title, type (client meeting, renewal review, new quote, claim help, insurer visit and so on), client (optional), time, place and notes. Click **Save**.
- Click a meeting to change or delete it.
- **Add to phone / Outlook (.ics)** on a meeting downloads it as a calendar entry with a 30-minute alert. Open the file on your phone or computer to add it to your own calendar.
- **Upcoming list** shows all future meetings in one list.

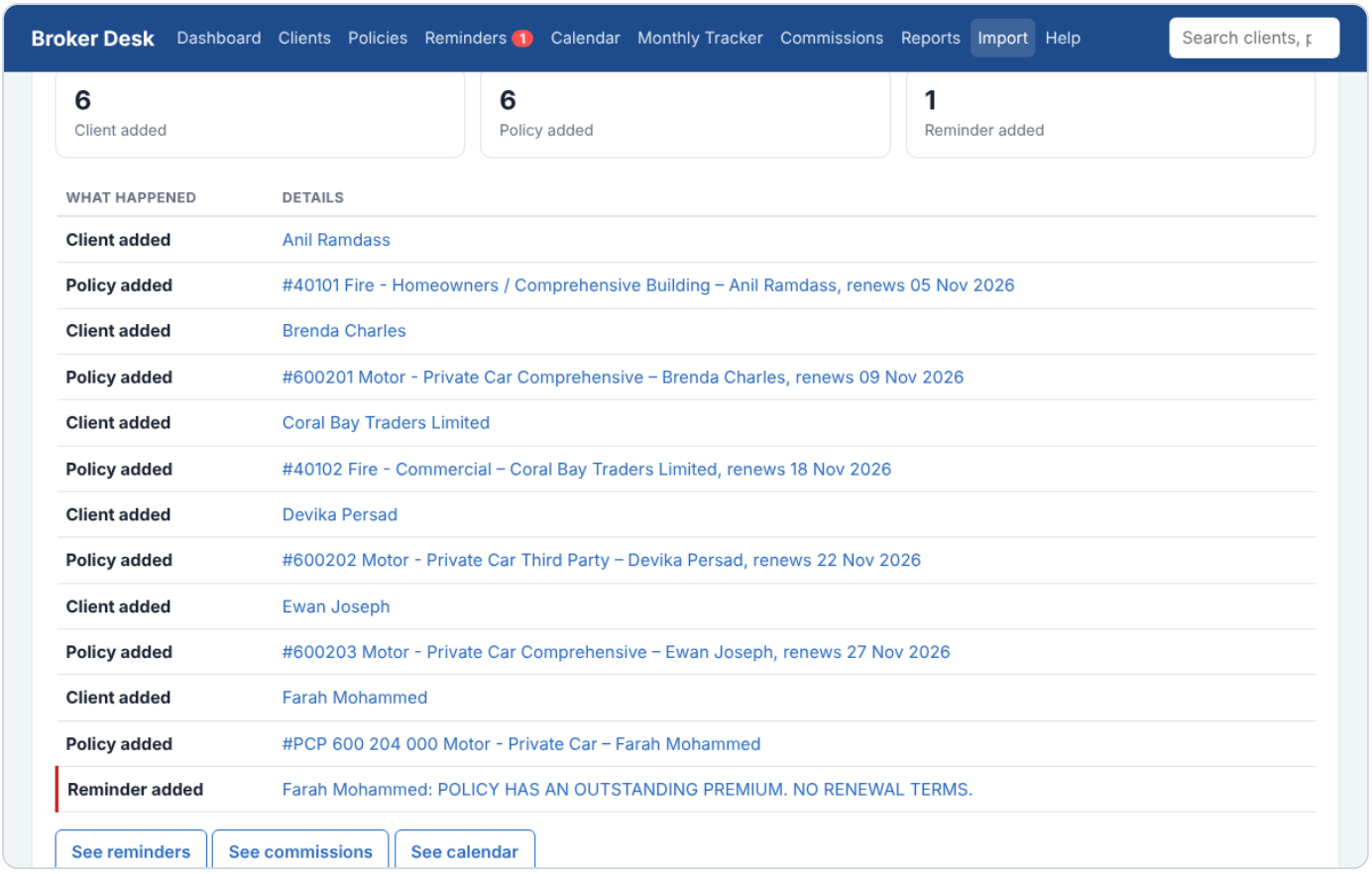
9. Importing insurer spreadsheets

Broker Desk reads the Excel reports the insurance company sends you, so you don't have to type them in.

Report	What the import does
Renewal listing LOB, POLICY, RENEWAL DATE, CLIENT NAME...	Adds or updates each client (address, phone) and policy (cover, sum insured, vehicle or property, discounts, premium). It sets the renewal date and the payment due, so they appear in Reminders, the Calendar and the Monthly Tracker. Policies with an outstanding premium get a reminder.
Commission statement ProdCode, InvPrefix, PolicyNo, InvoiceNo, Comm%, CommAmt...	Records every commission line on the **Commissions** page. It fills in the policy's period of insurance and commission rate, and marks those renewals as paid.

How to import

1. Click **Import**.
2. Click **Choose files** and select one or more spreadsheets (.xls, .xlsx or .csv). You can select several at once.
3. Check the **Insurance company** name. It's given to any new policies from these files.
4. Click **Import** and read the results list.

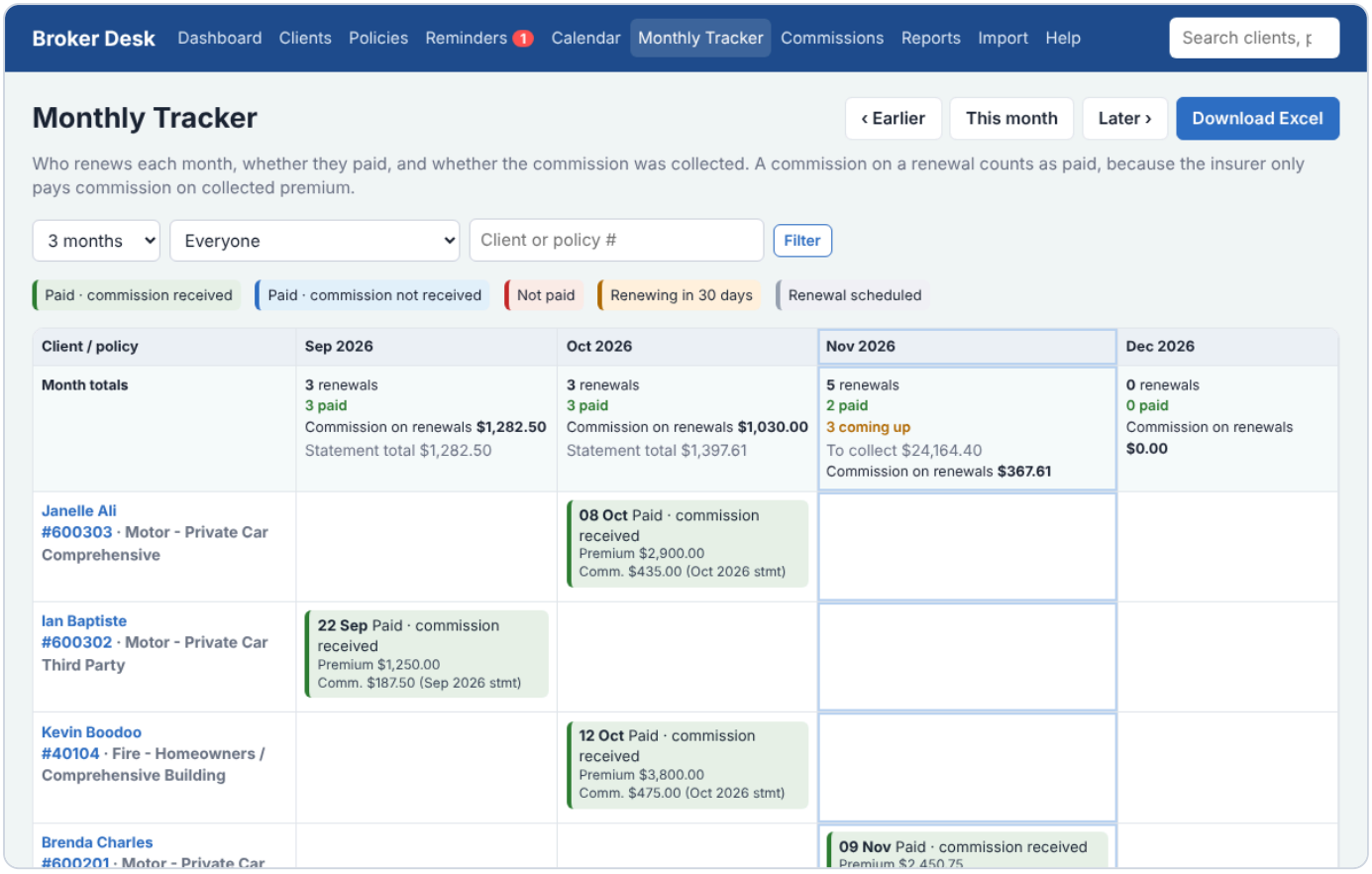


Import results: every client and policy added or updated, each with a link.

- **Importing the same file twice is safe.** Clients are matched by name, policies by policy number (even when written differently, such as "PCP 587 368 000" and 587368) and commission lines by invoice number. Nothing is doubled.
- If a file can't be read, you'll see a red line *"... was NOT imported. Nothing from this file was saved."* with the reason. Nothing from that file is saved, so you can fix the file and try again.
- Where the insurer's class code had to be interpreted (for example PCL = Private Car Comprehensive), the policy's notes say so. Correct the policy type with **Edit policy** if needed.

10. The Monthly Tracker

The Monthly Tracker answers three questions for every month: *who renews, who paid, and did the commission come in?*

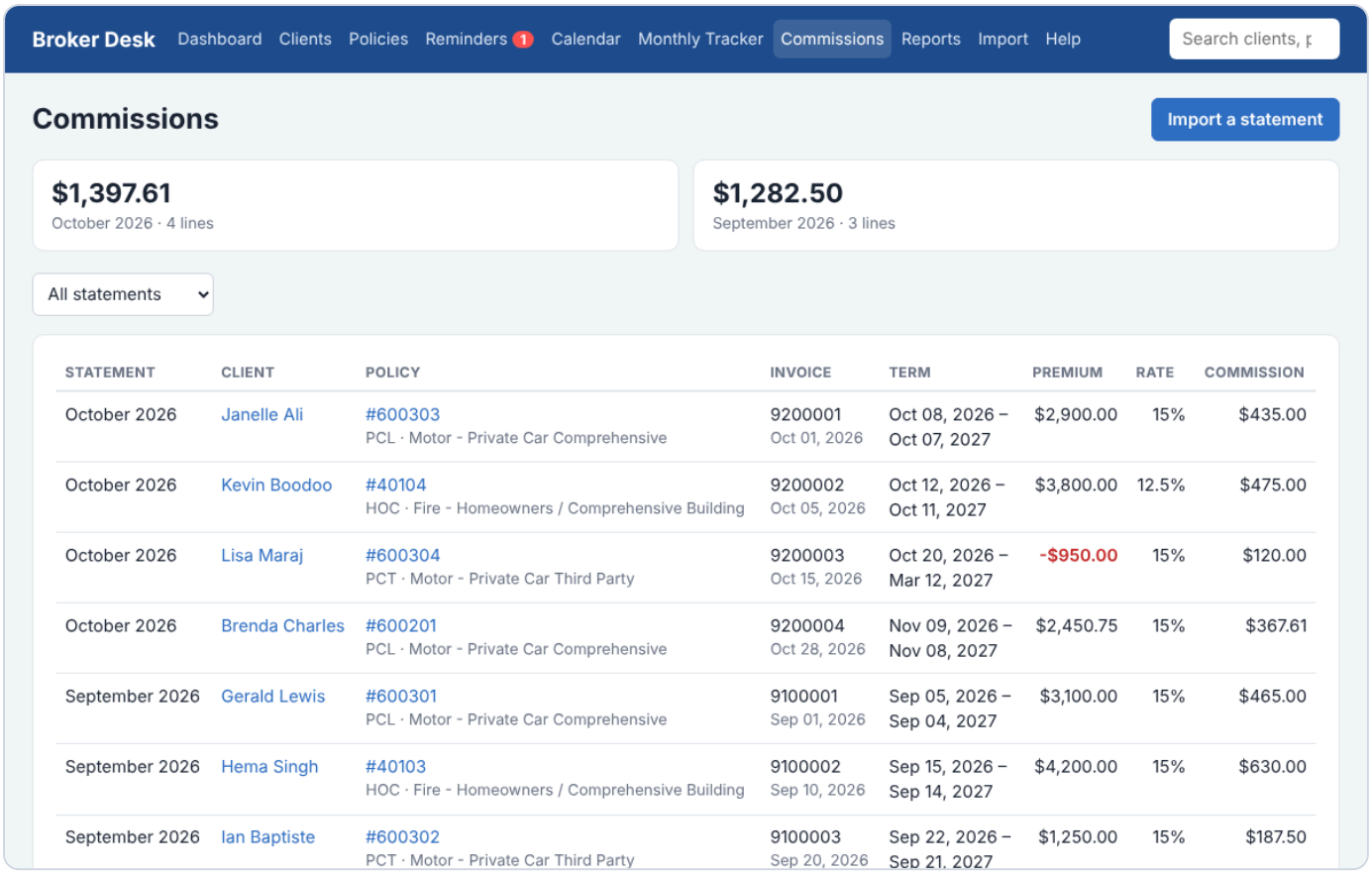


The Monthly Tracker: one row per policy, one column per month.

- Each coloured box is a renewal, showing the date, premium, amount paid and commission (with the statement it was on).
- **Month totals** at the top: renewals, paid, not paid, premium still to collect, commission received, commission still expected, and that month's statement total.
- Use **Earlier / This month / Later** and the *months* box to change the period.
- Use the **filter** to show only one group, for example:
  - *Not paid (past due)* gives a list of people to chase.
  - *Paid, commission not received* gives a list of commissions to query with the insurer.
- **Download Excel** saves the same grid, in colour, with a month-totals sheet.

> A renewal counts as **paid** if you recorded a payment for it *or* the insurer paid commission on it, because insurers only pay commission once the premium is collected.

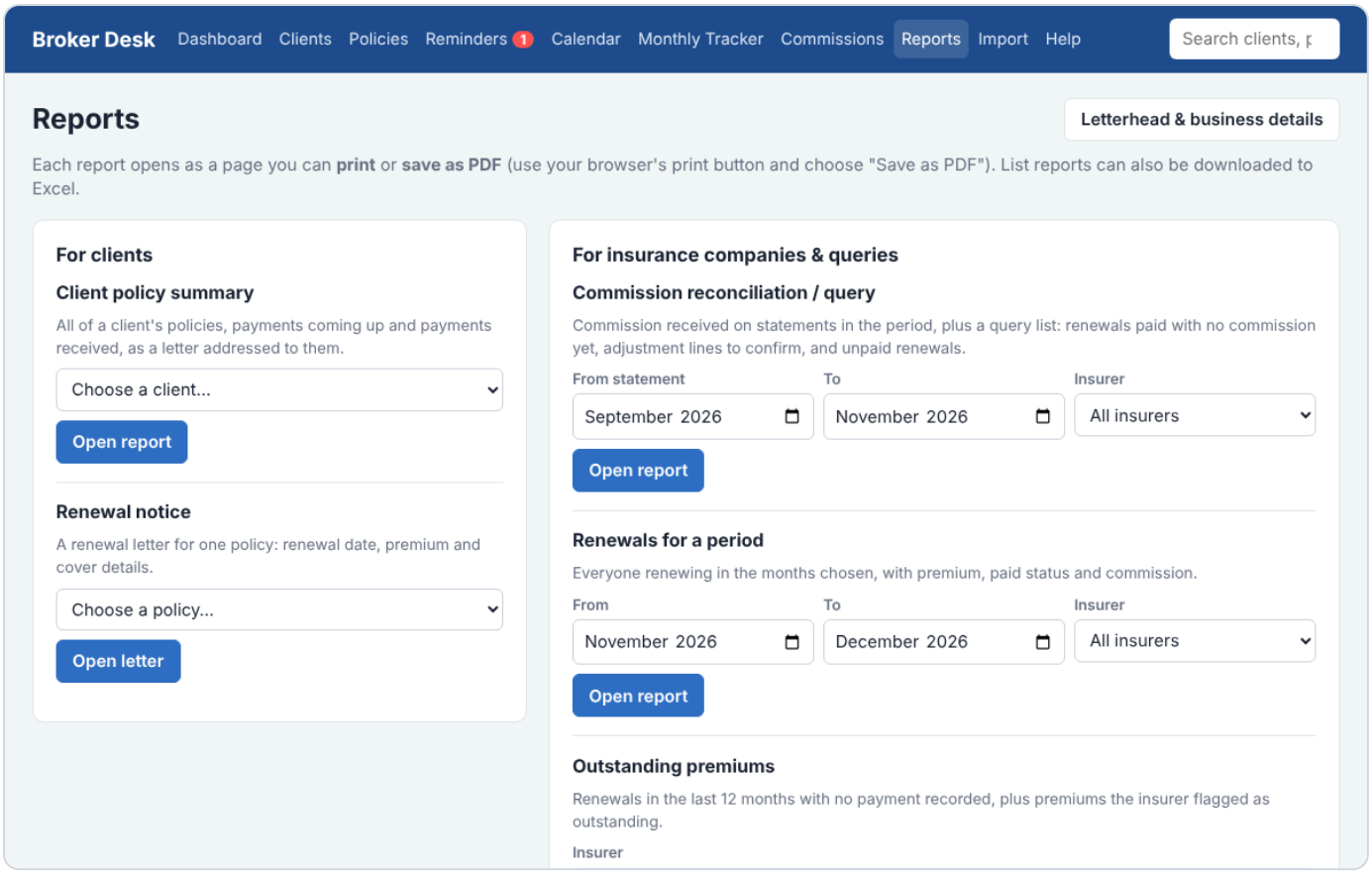
11. Commissions



The Commissions page

Shows every commission line imported from statements: client, policy, invoice, term, premium, rate and commission. The boxes at the top give each statement month's total. Click one to see only that month. Lines with a **negative premium** (adjustments or cancellations) appear in red. Check those with the insurer.

12. Reports and printing



The Reports page

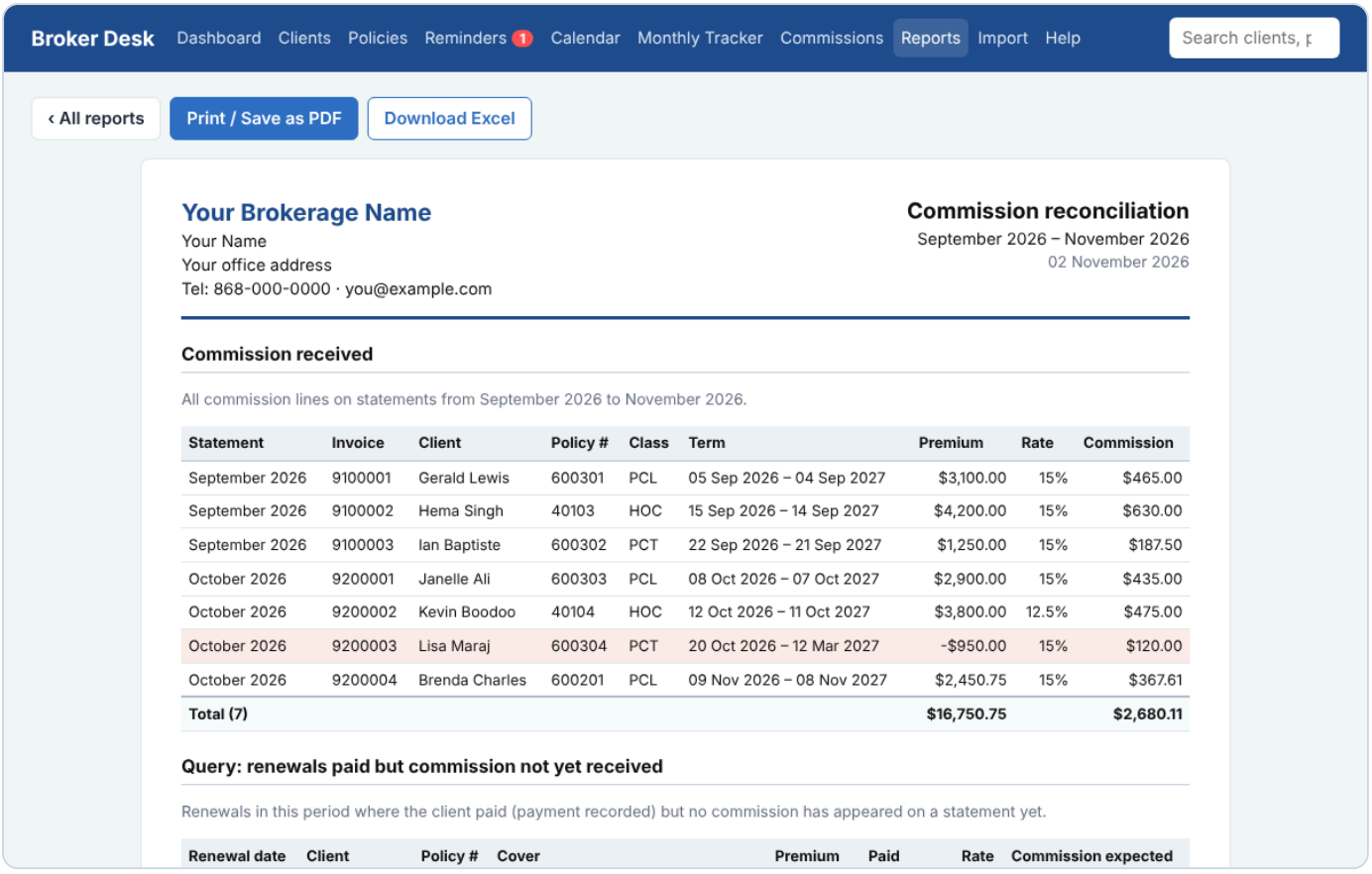
For clients

- **Client policy summary:** a letter to the client listing all their policies, what's coming due, and payments received.
- **Renewal notice:** a renewal letter for one policy with the renewal date, premium and cover details.

Client letters never show your commission.

For insurance companies and queries

- **Commission reconciliation / query:** commission received in the months you choose, plus three query lists: renewals paid with no commission yet, adjustment lines to confirm, and renewals not yet paid.
- **Renewals for a period:** everyone renewing in the chosen months, with status.
- **Outstanding premiums:** unpaid renewals in the last 12 months, plus premiums the insurer flagged.
- **Book of business:** every policy with period, sum insured, annual premium and estimated commission.
- **Policy history:** one policy in full, for answering an insurer's query.



A report ready to print, on your letterhead.

Printing or saving as PDF

1. Choose the report and options, then click **Open report**.
2. Click **Print / Save as PDF**.
3. In the print window, choose your printer, or choose **Save as PDF** as the destination to email the report. The menu and buttons aren't printed.

Insurer reports also have **Download Excel**.

13. Backups

Everything is stored in one database file on your website. To keep a copy:

1. Go to **Import**.
2. Click **Download backup**. A file named like `insurance-backup-2026-11-03.db` is saved.
3. Keep it somewhere safe: email it to yourself, or copy it to a USB drive or cloud folder.

Do this at least once a month (after your monthly import) and before deleting anything. The backup contains clients' personal information, so keep it private.

Restoring a backup

Go to **Import → Restore from a backup**, choose the backup file, tick the box and click **Restore this backup**. **All** the current data is replaced by the backup. Before that happens, a safety copy of the current data is saved in the `backups` folder. Your sign-in password stays the same.

14. Running it on your own computer or office network

Broker Desk can also run on your own laptop or office PC, with nothing stored on the internet. You use it in the browser exactly as now, and other computers and phones on the same office network or Wi-Fi can sign in too. The `READ ME FIRST.txt` file in the Broker Desk folder has the full steps. In short:

1. Install **Python** from python.org. On Windows, tick *Add python.exe to PATH*.
2. Unzip the **BrokerDesk** package into your Documents folder.
3. Double-click **Start Broker Desk** (`.bat` on Windows, `.command` on Mac). The first start takes a minute or two. After that it starts in seconds.
4. Your browser opens. **Create your password**.
5. To bring your data across: on the online version, click **Import → Download backup**; on the new copy, use **Import → Restore from a backup**.

Using it from other devices

The Broker Desk window shows an address like `http://192.168.1.20:8080`. Open it in the browser on any device on the same network and sign in. The main computer must be switched on, with the Broker Desk window open. On Windows, allow Python on *Private networks* when asked.

Where your data is

- `data/insurance.db`: your database.
- `data/backups/`: a backup is saved automatically each day (the last 60 are kept).
- `data/config.json`: settings. `"network": false` allows only this computer. `"port"` changes the address number.

Copy the `data` folder to a USB drive or cloud folder now and then. To install a newer version, unzip it and copy your `data` folder into it.

Starting Broker Desk automatically on Windows

Do this once. Broker Desk then starts by itself each time you sign in to Windows.

1. **Open the Startup folder.** Press the **Windows key + R**. In the small *Run* box, type `shell:startup` and press **Enter**. A folder window opens. Leave it open.
2. **Put a shortcut to Broker Desk in it.** In another window, open your **BrokerDesk** folder. Right-click `Start Broker Desk.bat` and choose **Show more options → Create shortcut** (on Windows 10, just **Create shortcut**). Drag the new shortcut into the Startup folder.
3. **Optional: start it minimised.** In the Startup folder, right-click the shortcut and choose **Properties**. Next to *Run*, choose **Minimized**, then click **OK**.
4. **Test it.** Restart the computer and sign in. After a few seconds Broker Desk starts and your browser opens on it.

- **Don't want the browser to open each time?** Open `data\config.json` in Notepad and change `"open_browser": true` to `"open_browser": false`.
- **Don't move or rename the BrokerDesk folder** afterwards, or the shortcut stops working. If you do move it, delete the old shortcut and repeat step 2.
- It starts when you **sign in** to Windows, not before. For other devices to use it, this computer must be on and signed in. Closing the Broker Desk window stops it.
- **To stop it starting automatically,** delete the shortcut from the Startup folder.
- If this is the office's main computer, set it never to sleep while plugged in (**Settings → System → Power**). Otherwise other devices lose their connection while it sleeps.

On a **Mac**: **System Settings → General → Login Items → +**, then choose `Start Broker Desk.command`.

Changing or resetting the password

Change it under **Reports → Letterhead & business details → Change password**. If you forget it: close Broker Desk, create an empty file named `reset-password.txt` in the `data` folder, start Broker Desk again, and create a new password on the main computer. Your data isn't affected.

15. Keeping the online website running

Every 3 months (free PythonAnywhere plan)

PythonAnywhere emails you before your site is paused. Log in at pythonanywhere.com, open the **Web** tab and click **Run until 3 months from today**. If you miss it, the site pauses but nothing is lost. Click the same button to start it again.

Getting new features and fixes

1. On PythonAnywhere, open a **Bash** console (Dashboard → *$ Bash*).
2. Type `bash ~/OP_Apps/deploy/update.sh` and press Enter.
3. When it says *Updated*, go to the **Web** tab and press the green **Reload** button.

Updates never touch your data.

Changing your password

On the Web tab, open the **WSGI configuration file**, change the text in the `TRACKER_PASSWORD` line, click **Save**, then **Reload**. Everyone is signed out and must use the new password.

16. Troubleshooting and questions

The site says "Something went wrong"

The page shows a short error message. Nothing from that action was saved. Send the message to whoever looks after the app. For the full details, on PythonAnywhere open the Web tab, then **Error log**, and copy the last lines.

An import says "NOT imported"

Nothing from that file was saved. The message gives the reason. The most common cause is a report in a different layout. Send the file and the message to whoever looks after the app.

A client appears twice

Names are matched exactly (ignoring capitals and punctuation), so "Stephen" and "Stephanie" are different clients. If the same person was typed two ways, move their policies to one client (Edit policy → Client) and delete the empty one.

A renewal shows as "Not paid" but the client paid

Open the policy and **Record payment**. When the commission statement arrives and is imported, the box turns green.

The dates look one day off

Broker Desk uses Trinidad and Tobago time. If you work in another time zone, ask for `TRACKER_TZ` to be changed in the WSGI file.

I forgot my password

Online version: set a new one in the WSGI file (see section 15). Own computer: see section 14.

Can more than one person use it?

Yes. Anyone with the web address and password can sign in, and they all see the same data.

17. What the colours and words mean

You see	Meaning
Paid · commission received	The renewal was paid and the commission is on a statement. Nothing to do.
Paid · commission not received	The client paid but no commission yet. Query the insurer if it's still missing after a month.
Not paid	The renewal date has passed with no payment recorded. Contact the client.
Renewing in 30 days	Send a renewal notice and collect the premium.
Renewal scheduled	A renewal further in the future.
Red number on *Reminders*	How many payments and to-dos are overdue.
Calendar colours	Blue meetings, red payments due, orange renewals, purple to-dos.
O/S premium	Outstanding premium shown on the insurer's listing.
Class codes (PCL, PCT, CGC, CGT, CCT, HOC, FC, PL, WC)	The insurer's codes for the type of cover: private car comprehensive or third party, commercial motor, homeowners fire, commercial fire, public liability, workers' compensation.
Term / Period of insurance	The dates the policy covers, usually one year.